



WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 1 · 1 October 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

This fortnight the conversation about artificial intelligence in education turned firmly towards Africa building its own capacity: Ghana will train 100,000 technical and vocational facilitators in AI, Ethiopia says AI will support rather than replace its teachers, and a member of the UN scientific panel urged the continent to design its own solutions rather than import them. For us at Wits AHEAD that is the heart of the matter, because the capability to use, question and build these tools well is formed in our classrooms. Welcome to our first full issue.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · 30 SEPTEMBER 2026 · GHANA

Ghana commits to train 100,000 TVET facilitators in AI under new UNESCO and Microsoft partnership

Ghana's Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) Service signed a memorandum of understanding with UNESCO, KPMG and Microsoft on 30 September 2026 to train at least 100,000 TVET facilitators in artificial intelligence and digital skills under the AI EmpowerED initiative. TVET Service director general Dr Eric Kofi Adzroe said the partnership marked a shift towards a system aligned with industry, powered by technology and focused on outcomes, while UNESCO country representative Edmond Moukala signed the agreement on the organisation's behalf.

Why it matters: For pillar 4, graduate capability, employability and just transitions, equipping technical and vocational instructors with AI skills at this scale could reshape how an entire generation of African artisans and technicians enters an AI reshaped labour market, a model Wits AHEAD watches for lessons applicable to South Africa's own TVET sector.

Graphic Online · graphic.com.gh · [Read at source](#)

2

REPORT · 30 SEPTEMBER 2026 · UNITED STATES

US learning platform data shows AI tools trail far behind other classroom technology

Instructure's new EdTech Top 40 report, based on anonymised data from 19.5 million higher education users of its Canvas learning platform between September 2025 and April 2026, found that Google Gemini, the most widely adopted dedicated AI tool, reached only 87,788 users across 211 institutions and failed to crack the top 100 integrated tools. Established tools such as McGraw Hill, with 11.3 million users, Watermark course evaluations and Zoom remained far more widely used. Instructure vice-president Ryan Lufkin said universities were signing enterprise wide AI deals without yet embedding the tools into everyday coursework.

Why it matters: For pillar 1, generative AI in higher education, the gap between institutional AI licensing and actual classroom use is a caution Wits AHEAD is tracking: buying access to AI tools is not the same as integrating them into teaching and assessment, and the group's own work on practical adoption speaks directly to that gap.

Inside Higher Ed · insidehighered.com · [Read at source](#)

3

NEWS · 30 SEPTEMBER 2026 · CHINA AND SOUTHEAST ASIA (RURAL COMMUNITIES)

UNESCO programme trains over 100 rural teachers and principals across China and Southeast Asia in AI and STEM

UNESCO reported on 30 September 2026 that its China-Southeast Asia Capacity Development Programme for Teachers and Principals, held in Beijing from 17 to 23 August 2026 under the theme 'STEM and AI: Empowering Rural Teachers for Digital Transformation', brought together over 100 education policymakers, school leaders, teachers and experts from China and Southeast Asian countries. Organised with UNESCO's International Research and Training Centre for Rural Education, SEAMEO RECSAM, the UNESCO Chair on Artificial Intelligence in Education at Beijing Normal University and the OECD, the programme focused on using AI and STEM teaching to advance digital equity in underserved rural communities. Professor Shahbaz Khan, director of UNESCO's Regional Office for East Asia, called for 'human centred, ethical and inclusive AI in education'.

Why it matters: For pillar 3, AI and analytics in STEM and teacher education, the programme's insistence that technology can support but never replace rural teachers offers a model Wits AHEAD can draw on for its own work preparing teacher educators across under resourced parts of the Global South.

UNESCO · unesco.org · [Read at source](#)

Cape Town hosts first African THE World Academic Summit as Wits and four other South African universities rise in the world rankings

Daily Maverick · 30 September 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For pillar 1, generative AI in higher education, UCT's decision to drop AI detection in favour of teaching proper use marks a shift in assessment policy that Wits AHEAD is tracking across the sector, and the rankings rise together with the Minister's unemployment figure underline why AI, analytics and graduate capability matter for every South African university, Wits included.

Ethiopia's Education Ministry says AI will support, not replace, teachers as it expands digital learning

allAfrica (Ethiopian News Agency) · 29 September 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For pillar 1, generative AI in higher education, and pillar 5, analytics and data for education systems, a national ministry publicly committing to AI as a support for teachers rather than a replacement, alongside systems level data reform, is the kind of policy signal Wits AHEAD tracks across the Global South.

Africa must build its own AI solutions rather than import them, says UN scientific panel member

allAfrica (UN News) · 25 September 2026 · Pillar 6: Responsible AI and policy. For pillar 6, responsible AI, ethics, equity and policy, a UN scientific adviser explicitly naming universities as essential partners in a locally led AI agenda reinforces the case for Wits AHEAD's own emphasis on African owned research and solutions, not imported frameworks.

African universities can drive talent development at scale, Mastercard Foundation tells Accra convening

University World News · 24 September 2026 · Pillar 4: Graduate capability and just transitions. For pillar 4, graduate capability, employability and just transitions, a major funder framing universities as talent infrastructure, while naming AI as a force reshaping work, strengthens the case for Wits AHEAD's evidence on which graduate capabilities actually lead to dignified work in African labour markets.

FROM THE GROUP

12 Sep 2026 Partnership with Murdoch University, Perth, in development

Joint work on AI and education between Wits and Murdoch; a memorandum of understanding is in preparation.

A READING WE PROFFER

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). The H in AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,

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